













AUDIO GA GA

Here are a few things to listen to...

1. Buri Nazar
2. Bhaskar Bose
3. Permanent Roommates
4. Virus 2062
5. The Last Girl to Fall in Love
6. The Sandman
7. Baby Doll

Mugdh has seen the audio industry come of age since he launched MnM in 2016. Getting actors on board is no longer the huge ask it once used to be. "A lot of my friends would earlier tell me, 'What even is an audio drama, man? Make an OTT series'," he says. "Now, it's 'How about casting us?'"

SOUND PRINCIPLE

Having worked with a range of actors, from Amitabh Bachchan (*Kaali Awaazein*) to Richa Chadha, Mugdh will tell you that voice acting is not easier said than done. "The moment an actor, regardless of experience, steps in front of the microphone," he says, "they suddenly find themselves deprived of all tools—their body, eyes, demeanour and approach. A lot of polished actors and veterans come [into the studio] and stumble for the first few minutes. You have to calm them down, ask them to close their eyes and imagine themselves."

Actor Vijay Varma is all too familiar with how "daunting" voice acting can be as he dicovered while doing his gig recently, playing the lead role of Dream a.k.a. Morpheus in Audible India's adaptation of Neil Gaiman's popular Sandman comics. "I was a nervous wreck and under-confident," says Varma. "There's nobody else in the room. You are not seeing yourself, you are not seeing anything, in fact, and you are bereft of the other senses. You are left with just one skill, speech, and you have to paint an entire picture with it. It's your job to be creative with it." It would take Varma hours to find his rhythm and arrive at "a place where I was like, I can do more".

It's this challenge and the realisation that there's plenty room to hone your craft that is seeing actors like Varma seek out recording studios such as Sound & Vision India. In the United Kingdom, Dirk Maggs, one of the most celebrated and feted directors in radio, has Benedict Cumberbatch, James McAvoy, Brian Cox and John Lithgow working for him. With many of them exposed to BBC's radio dramas, they don't think of audio as a lesser medium. For *Sandman Part 3*, Maggs hints at a leading Indian actor joining the fray. He says there are only perks for actors lending their voice. "There's a no make-up, no sitting in the trailer [vanity van], you just do the part from A-Z and have fun in the [recording] studio." Actors are simply left to themselves in a soundproof studio. Also, unlike a feature